

GREATER

TEXT: Matthew 1:18-25 (NKJV) *“Now the birth of Jesus Christ was as follows: After His mother Mary was betrothed to Joseph, before they came together, she was found with child of the Holy Spirit. ¹⁹ Then Joseph her husband, being a just man, and not wanting to make her a public example, was minded to put her away secretly. ²⁰ But while he thought about these things, behold, an angel of the Lord appeared to him in a dream, saying, “Joseph, son of David, do not be afraid to take to you Mary your wife, for that which is conceived in her is of the Holy Spirit. ²¹ And she will bring forth a Son, and you shall call His name Jesus, for He will save His people from their sins.” ²² So all this was done that it might be fulfilled which was spoken by the Lord through the prophet, saying: ²³ “Behold, the virgin shall be with child, and bear a Son, and they shall call His name Immanuel,” which is translated, “God*

with us.”²⁴ Then Joseph, being aroused from sleep, did as the angel of the Lord commanded him and took to him his wife,²⁵ and did not know her till she had brought forth her firstborn Son. And he called His name Jesus.”

INTRO: December is my favorite time of year to preach a series. There is so much material in the Christmas story, that I don't know if one could ever exhaust the supply of information.

Always before, I have focused on the events surrounding the birth of Jesus, but this year I want to take a walk through His life – Beginning with His conception, and ending with His office as eternal intercessor. In doing so, I want to focus on His life using the word, **“GREATER”**.

**THE CONCEPTION OF THE
CHRISTCHILD WAS GREAT**

The Prophet Isaiah writing seven hundred years before the Birth of Christ made the bold prediction that... “*A virgin shall conceive...*”

What? You heard it right... “*A virgin shall conceive...*” Can you imagine what the people to whom Isaiah was speaking, thought of such a comment? Never before in the history of the world was the conception of a child initiated in such a manner.

After such an outlandish prediction, Isaiah wouldn't be proven correct in his lifetime – In fact, this prophecy wouldn't be fulfilled for more than seven centuries! (I like my prophecies to come to pass a little sooner)

This Christmas story begins with the miracle of the conception of the Christ Child, and ends with His Glorious Resurrection. Paul tells the Corinthian Christians, “*If Christ be not raised, your preaching is in vain, your faith is in vain, and you are yet in your sins.*”

Listen to what the Angel said to Mary:

- Luke 1:26-35 (NKJV) *“The angel Gabriel was sent by God to a city of Galilee named Nazareth, ²⁷ to a virgin betrothed to a man whose name was Joseph, of the house of David. The virgin’s name was Mary. ²⁸ And having come in, the angel said to her, “Rejoice, highly favored one, the Lord is with you; blessed are you among women!” ²⁹ But when she saw him, she was troubled at his saying, and considered what manner of greeting this was. ³⁰ Then the angel said to her, “Do not be afraid, Mary, for you have found favor with God. ³¹ And behold, you will conceive in your womb and bring forth a Son, and shall call His name Jesus. ³² He will be great, and will be called the Son of the Highest; and the Lord God will give Him the throne of His father David. ³³ And He will reign over the house of Jacob forever, and of His kingdom there will be no end.” ³⁴ Then Mary said to the angel, “How can this be, since I do not*

know a man?”³⁵ And the angel answered and said to her, “The Holy Spirit will come upon you, and the power of the Highest will overshadow you; therefore, also, that Holy One who is to be born will be called the Son of God.”³⁶ Now indeed, Elizabeth your relative has also conceived a son in her old age; and this is now the sixth month for her who was called barren.³⁷ For with God nothing will be impossible.”

Listen to what the Angel said to Joseph:

- Matthew 1:20-21 (NKJV) *“An angel of the Lord appeared to him in a dream, saying, “Joseph, son of David, do not be afraid to take to you Mary your wife, for that which is conceived in her is of the Holy Spirit.²¹ And she will bring forth a Son, and you shall call His name Jesus, for He will save His people from their sins.”*

Of the twenty billion people who have called planet Earth home, only one baby has ever been born without the DNA of an earthly father.

As insane as it sounds, Jesus was born of a Virgin Birth.

To begin with, this very detail sets Him apart from every other imposter who has ever claimed to be, or will ever claim to be, the Messiah. In the words of this current culture, “*You just can’t make this stuff up.*”

The Virgin Birth is the initial flash point of a life that would be marked by the miraculous and the supernatural.

To many people the Virgin Birth is too fantastic for them to believe. In such a case, those who can’t get their head around the Virgin Birth, can never believe His sacrifice on Calvary can forgive sin. The bedrock of our faith is believing in His Virgin Birth.

HIS CONCEPTION WAS GREAT – BUT HIS BIRTH WAS GREATER

In the account of the Angel appearing to the shepherds, announcing Christ's birth, the Word describes a scene in which the shepherds actually witness the physical manifestation of the light of Christ! Luke 2:9-14 (NKJV) ***“And behold, an angel of the Lord stood before them, and the glory of the Lord shone around them, and they were greatly afraid.”***¹⁰ ***Then the angel said to them, “Do not be afraid, for behold, I bring you good tidings of great joy which will be to all people.”***¹¹ ***For there is born to you this day in the city of David a Savior, who is Christ the Lord.***¹² ***And this will be the sign to you: You will find a Babe wrapped in swaddling cloths, lying in a manger.”***¹³ ***And suddenly there was with the angel a multitude of the heavenly host praising God and saying:***¹⁴ ***“Glory to God in the highest, And on earth peace, goodwill toward men!”***

In this tiny baby, there was so much of the wisdom of God wrapped in swaddling clothes, that the very announcement of His birth gave such light, that the shepherds were frightened.

The moment that Jesus was born, He became God incarnate! God, took upon Himself the form of human flesh and was presented as Bethlehem's baby. It was at this moment that:

- God's Son became Mary's Baby...
- A child was born, but a son was given....
- The Lion of the Tribe of Judah became a lamb slain from the foundation of the world... (From everlasting to everlasting – Eternal Priesthood after the order – Before Abraham was, I am)
- An equal to God became a lowly servant of all mankind...
- The Ancient of Days became an infant born in the stable of Bethlehem...

- The Omnipotent became a dependent life to be fed, clothed and nourished by human hands...
- He placed himself in the hands of man, that man might place himself in the hands of God... (Cast ourselves upon the mercies of God – His mercies are new every morning – Casting all our cares upon Him)

The miracle of the incarnation is why one of his names is ***“Immanuel–God with us.”***

This baby, came from Heaven; was announced by Angels; appeared to shepherds; sought by wise men; disrupted starry constellations; hated by this worlds system; sought by the king; yet born in a manger!

Exactly who was Bethlehem’s baby?

- He is the Ancient Of Day’s...
- He is the Bright And Morning Star...

- He is the Chief Cornerstone...
- He is the Daystar Who Shines Down On Us...
- He is the Everlasting Father...
- He is the Faithful And True Witness...
- He is the Good Shepherd...
- He is the Great High Priest...
- He is the I Am Of Yesterday, Today, And Tomorrow...
- He is the Judge And Law Giver...
- He is King Of King And Lord Of Lords...
- He is the Lion Of The Tribe Of Judah...
- He is Mary's Baby...
- He is Bethlehem's Most Famous Child...
- He is the Nazarene Of all Nazarene's...
- He is the Only Begotten Son Of God...
- He is the Prince Whose Coming Brings Peace...
- He is The Altogether Lovely One...
- He is the Rose Of Sharon...
- He is Shiloh Savior...
- He is the True Witness...

- He is the Undisputed Champion Of All Times...
- He is The Only One Who Brings Victory...
- He is the Expected Messiah...
- He is Zion's Deliverer...

CONCLUSION:

This baby born in Bethlehem changed everything about the world, and changes the world for everyone who comes into relationship with Him.

(Give Altar Call for the Lost – Pray for all other needs)

END OF SERMON ONE

GREATER

TEXT: Matthew 1:18-25 (NKJV) *“Now the birth of Jesus Christ was as follows: After His mother Mary was betrothed to Joseph, before they came together, she was found with child of the Holy Spirit. ¹⁹ Then Joseph her husband, being a just man, and not wanting to make her a public example, was minded to put her away secretly. ²⁰ But while he thought about these things, behold, an angel of the Lord appeared to him in a dream, saying, “Joseph, son of David, do not be afraid to take to you Mary your wife, for that which is conceived in her is of the Holy Spirit. ²¹ And she will bring forth a Son, and you shall call His name Jesus, for He will save His people from their sins.” ²² So all this was done that it might be fulfilled which was spoken by the Lord through the prophet, saying: ²³ “Behold, the virgin shall be with child, and bear a Son, and they shall call His name Immanuel,” which is translated, “God*

with us.”²⁴ Then Joseph, being aroused from sleep, did as the angel of the Lord commanded him and took to him his wife,²⁵ and did not know her till she had brought forth her firstborn Son. And he called His name Jesus.”

INTRO: Last week we talked about the Conception of the Christ Child being **GREAT**. We also talked about the Birth of the Christ Child being **GREATER** than His Conception.

HIS BIRTH WAS GREAT – BUT HIS SINLESS LIFE WAS GREATER

Think of this... 33 ½ sinless years! Hebrews 4:15 *“He was tempted in all points, as we are. Yet, He did not sin!”*

Tell me if anyone in here has been able to live to this point in 2023 without committing a sin? How about the last six months? How about the last thirty days? How about the last week?

33 ½ sinless years! His conception and Virgin Birth was great, but 33 ½ sinless years had to be **GREATER!**

Through His sinless life we witness:

- All the strength of His Deity residing in His spirit...
- All the power of God being invested into His hands...
- All the people of God being committed to His safe keeping...
- All the direction of God for road weary travelers being found in His steps...
- All the timelessness of God being seen in His deliberate life....
- All the forgiveness of God was on display through His sinless life...

Look at the results of His sinless Life:

- He prevented a wedding reception in Cana of Galilee from self-destructing, by turning the water into wine...

- He revived a nobleman's son, who had been given a terminal diagnosis...
- He told a group of bankrupt fishermen where to fish, and the fishing business boomed...
- He set free a demoniac in the synagogue...
- He healed ten lepers who had been banished to the leper colony...
- He healed the fevered brow of Peter's mother-in-law...
- He healed a man who was in the final stages of cerebral palsy...
- He healed a man with a withered hand...
- He stopped a funeral procession, to heal a widow woman's dead son...
- He delivered a demon-possessed man who had terrorized his community...
- He raised up the dead daughter of Jairus...
- He stopped the flow of blood for a woman who had been hemorrhaging for twelve straight years...
- He quenched the hunger of a crowd of

thousands, with the lunch of a young boy...

- He restored the sight of a man born blind, using dirt and saliva...
- He paid the IRS debt of the disciples, with money He predicted would be in the mouth of a fish...
- He reestablished the life of a woman who had been married five times, and was shacking up with her current lover...
- He restored the speech and hearing of a deaf mute, by spitting on his fingers, and placing them in the ears, and on the tongue of the deaf mute...
- He raised Lazarus from the dead by simply speaking the word...
- On the eve of His crucifixion, He reattached the ear of Malchus, after Simon Peter cut it off...
- He counseled a thief into the Kingdom of God, while he was hanging on a cross...

His Birth was no doubt **GREAT** but His sinless life was **GREATER!**

HIS SINLESS LIFE WAS GREAT BUT HIS SUBSTITUTIONARY DEATH WAS GREATER

Look at what His substitutionary death produced: Isaiah 53:5 (NKJV) *“But He was wounded for our transgressions, He was bruised for our iniquities; The chastisement for our peace was upon Him, And by His stripes we are healed.”*

- He was bruised and brought healing...
- He was pierced and eased pain...
- He was persecuted and brought freedom...
- He was dead and brought life...

The ordeal of the cross seems to be a crushing defeat! The Son of God, hanged on a tree until dead! It appears that so much was lost at the cross. The Disciples and the Christ followers of the day certainly felt that way.

Jesus willingly gave up His earthly life on the cross, but look at what He didn't give up on the cross:

- His dignity... Luke 23:28 (KJV) *"But Jesus turning unto them said, Daughters of Jerusalem, weep not for me, but weep for yourselves, and for your children."* Luke 23:34 (KJV) *"Then said Jesus, Father, forgive them; for they know not what they do..."* He was a class act; He kept his dignity!
- His deity... Matthew 27:54 (KJV) *"Now when the centurion, and they that were with him, watching Jesus, saw the earthquake, and those things that were done, they feared greatly, saying, Truly this was the Son of God."* Not one time during His life, death, burial or resurrection did Jesus lay down His deity; not even for one minute.
- His destiny... 1 John 3:8 (KJV) *"...For this purpose the Son of God was manifested, that he might destroy the works of the*

devil. " Colossians 2:15 (KJV) "***And having spoiled principalities and powers, he made a show of them openly, triumphing over them in it.***"

CONCLUSION:

The crucifixion of Jesus changed the symbol of the cross from an instrument of capital punishment, to a worldwide pictogram of freedom and victory.

(Talk about what one thinks when they see a cross – This is true worldwide)

(Song – The Old Rugged Cross)

*“On a hill far away, stood an old rugged cross
the emblem of suffering and shame. And I love
that old cross where the dearest and best, for a
world of lost sinners was slain.*

*To the old rugged cross, I will ever be true.
It's shame and reproach gladly bear. Then he'll*

*call me some day, to my home far away. Where
his glory forever I'll share.*

*So I'll cherish the old rugged cross. Till my
trophy at last I lay down. And I will cling to
the old rugged cross. And exchange it some day
for a crown.”*

(Communion)

END OF SERMON TWO

GREATER

TEXT: Matthew 1:18-25 (NKJV) *“Now the birth of Jesus Christ was as follows: After His mother Mary was betrothed to Joseph, before they came together, she was found with child of the Holy Spirit. ¹⁹ Then Joseph her husband, being a just man, and not wanting to make her a public example, was minded to put her away secretly. ²⁰ But while he thought about these things, behold, an angel of the Lord appeared to him in a dream, saying, “Joseph, son of David, do not be afraid to take to you Mary your wife, for that which is conceived in her is of the Holy Spirit. ²¹ And she will bring forth a Son, and you shall call His name Jesus, for He will save His people from their sins.” ²² So all this was done that it might be fulfilled which was spoken by the Lord through the prophet, saying: ²³ “Behold, the virgin shall be with child, and bear a Son, and they shall call His name Immanuel,” which is translated, “God*

with us.”²⁴ Then Joseph, being aroused from sleep, did as the angel of the Lord commanded him and took to him his wife,²⁵ and did not know her till she had brought forth her firstborn Son. And he called His name Jesus.”

INTRO: In the last couple weeks we have talked about:

- The Conception of Jesus being Great...
- The Birth of Jesus being Greater than the Conception of Jesus...
- The Sinless Life of Jesus being Greater than the Conception and Birth of Jesus...

Today I want to talk about...

HIS SUBSTITUTIONARY DEATH WAS GREAT – BUT HIS RESURRECTION WAS GREATER

The prophet Isaiah predicted, *“He shall become known as the Mighty God or the Strong, Valiant Warrior.”* In part, He received this title

for His three-day-stay in the heart of the earth. It was during His three-day-absence, He conquered the keys of death and hell.

On the third day He arose from the tomb. Paul told the Corinthians that the Resurrection was the greatest event in the History of the world.

“If Christ be not raised then your preaching is in vain, your faith is in vain, and you are yet in your sins.”

Jesus’ life, death, burial, and resurrection produced the following results:

- He whipped every devil and demon in Heaven and hell, so that He could come to earth and become THE sacrifice for sin...
- He thrashed every entity that made an attempt to thwart His plan for the ages...
- He beat back every temptation He faced in thirty-three and one-half years of living on this earth...
- He pounded every demon possessed entity who rejected and taunted Him, in an attempt

to short-circuit the salvation process...

- He destroyed every power and influence that attempted to hold Him in a borrowed tomb...
- He hammered every evil force who has ever opposed His children...

Because of His Resurrection:

- We are on the winning team...
- He will grant to us victory for every battle...
- There is nothing impossible for Him...
- There is nothing impossible for us...
- The world is waiting for the manifestation of the sons and daughters of God...

As a result of His Resurrection:

- He is our advocate...
- He is our beloved...
- He is our comfort...
- He is our deliverer...
- He is our eternity...

- He is our friend forever...
- He is our guide...
- He is our holiness...
- He is our insurance beyond the grave,
protection for our souls...
- He is our joy...
- He is our King...
- He is our Lord...
- He is our most prized possession...
- He is the neutralizer for our nature...
- He is the best opportunity we have ever
had...
- He is our peace...
- He is the quality control for our soul...
- He is our Redeemer...
- He is our Savior...
- He is the true vine and we are His
branches...
- He is the unction that keeps our fire for
ministry burning...
- He is the victorious, valiant, champion of
our salvation...

- He is our way into His kingdom...
- He exemplifies all that we desire to be...
- He renews our youth from time to time...
- He zeroes us in on Heaven...

Think of this:

- The Pharisees couldn't confuse Him...
- Herod couldn't kill Him...
- Nero couldn't crush Him...
- The armies couldn't derail Him...
- Death couldn't defeat Him...
- The grave couldn't hold Him...
- The world doesn't understand Him...
- The leaders can't ignore Him...

He gives us eternal life because it is His to give!
 (Larissa telling a Board Member “*My Daddy owns this whole place!*”)

He is:

- The alpha and the omega...

- The first and the last...
- The beginning and the end...
- The keeper of creation...
- The creator of all...
- The architect of the universe...
- The manager of everything...

HIS RESURRECTION WAS GREAT – BUT HIS OFFICE AS INTERCESSOR IS GREATER

Hebrews 10:11-14 (NKJV) *“Every priest stands ministering daily and offering repeatedly the same sacrifices, which can never take away sins. ¹² But this Man, after He had offered one sacrifice for sins forever, sat down at the right hand of God, ¹³ from that time waiting till His enemies are made His footstool. ¹⁴ For by one offering He has perfected forever those who are being sanctified.”*

As the eternal intercessor, Jesus:

- Fights for the righteous...
- Fights for righteousness...
- Fights to save lives...
- Fights to save the lost...
- Fights to save marriages...
- Fights to save churches...
- Fights to save you and me...

The baby born in Bethlehem's manger was not just the Son of God; He is also God the Son.

As the eternal intercessor He:

- Has never seen a problem He could not resolve...
- Has never seen a hurt He could not heal...
- Has never seen a battle He could not win...
- Has never seen a question He could not answer...
- Has never seen an obligation He could not meet...
- Has never seen a failure He could not fix...

- Has never seen a loss He could not restore...

As eternal intercessor:

- When we fail, He forgives us!
- When we fall, He lifts us up!
- When we are weak, He is strong!
- When we are lost, He is the Way!
- When we are afraid, He is our courage!
- When we stumble, He steadies us!
- When we are broken, He mends us!
- When we are blind, He gives us sight!
- When we are hungry, He feeds us!
- When we face trials, He is with us!
- When we face persecution, He shields us!
- When we face problems, He comforts us!
- When we encounter loss, He provides for us!

CONCLUSION:

Because He is our eternal intercessor we can rest assured:

- He will never leave us...
- He will never forsake us...
- He will never mislead us...
- He will never forget us...
- He will never overlook us...
- He will never mistreat us...
- He will never cancel our appointment in HIS appointment book... (Larissa calling the office and asking me to come home)